



MULTIMEDIA UNIVERSITY OF KENYA

FACULTY OF COMPUTING & INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

**BRIDGING THE INFORMAL LABOUR MARKET: A WEB PLATFORM FOR
BLUE-COLLAR SERVICE CONNECTIVITY IN KENYA**

BY

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Software Engineering/Computer Science

DECLARATION

I hereby declare that this Project is my own work and has, to the best of my knowledge, not been submitted to any other institution of higher learning.

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This project has been submitted as a partial fulfillment of requirements for the Bachelor of Science in Software Engineering of Multimedia University of Kenya with my approval as the University supervisor.

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ABSTRACT

The blue-collar workforce in Kenya, including electricians, plumbers, mechanics, painters, and cleaners, plays a critical role in the economy. However, most independent workers face challenges such as irregular employment, limited digital visibility, and reliance on informal networks like word-of-mouth referrals. Clients seeking these services often struggle to post jobs, find skilled and reliable workers nearby, and coordinate service delivery, resulting in delays, inconsistent quality, and low trust.

This study explores the development of a mobile platform that connects blue-collar workers with clients, focusing on its design, implementation, and potential impact on the local labour market. By providing a transparent, efficient, and reliable digital marketplace, the platform aims to increase employment opportunities for workers, improve access to verified services for clients, and reduce inefficiencies caused by traditional referral systems.

The study involves analysing user requirements, designing a high-fidelity prototype, and developing a functional MVP. The platform's usability and effectiveness will be evaluated through user testing with both workers and clients to assess its impact on job accessibility, service reliability, and overall user satisfaction.

This research demonstrates a viable technological approach to formalizing informal labour markets, empowering skilled workers, and providing a dependable, convenient, and trustworthy solution for accessing local services.

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List of Abbreviations

MVP – Minimum Viable Product

UI – User Interface

UX – User Experience

API – Application Programming Interface

HTML – HyperText Markup Language

CSS – Cascading Style Sheets

SSD – Solid State Drive

RAM – Random Access Memory

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Chapter 1 - INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of study

The global labour market is undergoing a rapid digital transformation that is reshaping how employment opportunities are created, accessed, and managed. Digital platforms have significantly improved job visibility, reduced information asymmetry, and enabled workers to market their skills beyond traditional geographic and social boundaries. According to the International Labour Organization (ILO, 2021), digital labour platforms have expanded rapidly over the past decade, creating new forms of work and income opportunities worldwide. However, the benefits of this transformation have not been evenly distributed across all sectors of the workforce. Blue-collar and skilled trade workers, particularly those operating within informal economies, remain significantly underserved by modern digital solutions.

Blue-collar workers—including plumbers, electricians, carpenters, mechanics, painters, cleaners, and other skilled artisans—play a vital role in economic development by providing essential services to households, small businesses, and public institutions. In Kenya, the informal sector dominates employment. According to the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS, 2023), over 80 percent of total employment in Kenya is generated within the informal sector. A substantial proportion of blue-collar workers operate within this segment, where employment opportunities are primarily accessed through word-of-mouth referrals, personal networks, and physical recommendations. While these traditional methods provide a basic level of trust, they are geographically limited, inconsistent, and increasingly inefficient in a rapidly urbanizing and mobile society.

The continued reliance on informal hiring mechanisms presents significant challenges for both workers and clients. Skilled workers frequently experience irregular employment and income instability, not due to lack of competence, but because their visibility is restricted to narrow social circles. At the same time, individuals and small businesses seeking blue-collar services often struggle to identify skilled, reliable, and nearby service providers. The absence of centralized and transparent verification systems increases the risk of fraud, inconsistent service quality, and pricing uncertainty. This situation reflects a persistent information asymmetry between labour supply and service demand within Kenya's informal economy.

Concurrently, Kenya has experienced substantial growth in smartphone adoption and mobile internet usage. Reports indicate that mobile penetration in Kenya exceeds 100 percent subscription rates, with increasing smartphone adoption even among low-income populations (Communications Authority of Kenya, 2023; GSMA, 2022). This digital expansion presents a strategic opportunity to modernize labour market access through mobile-based solutions. Despite the proven effectiveness of digital platforms in other sectors, existing systems have not adequately addressed the unique needs, literacy levels, and work patterns of independent blue-collar workers. Many platforms rely on competitive bidding models, favour established businesses, or lack robust trust and verification mechanisms, thereby limiting inclusive participation.

Given that the informal sector constitutes the backbone of Kenya's employment structure, the absence of a dedicated, accessible, and trust-centred digital platform for blue-collar workers represents a critical structural gap. Without intervention, inefficiencies in service discovery, limited worker visibility, and persistent trust deficits will continue to constrain economic opportunities within this sector.

This study therefore seeks to examine the feasibility, design, and potential impact of a mobile application-based platform aimed at bridging this digital divide and enhancing transparency, access, and trust within Kenya's blue-collar labour market.

1.2 Problem Statement

Despite the critical role played by blue-collar workers in Kenya's economy, the process of connecting skilled artisans such as electricians, plumbers, mechanics, painters, and cleaners with potential clients remains largely informal, fragmented, and inefficient. According to the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS, 2023), the informal sector accounts for over 80% of total employment in Kenya, with millions of workers operating outside formal employment structures. A significant proportion of blue-collar workers fall within this sector, where employment opportunities are primarily accessed through word-of-mouth referrals and physical networks that are geographically limited and unable to meet the demands of an increasingly urbanized and mobile society.

For skilled workers, this reliance on informal hiring mechanisms results in persistent underemployment, income instability, and prolonged periods without work—not due to a lack of skills, but because their visibility is restricted to narrow social and geographic circles. Despite the rapid growth of digital labour platforms globally—whose numbers have increased more than fivefold over the past decade (ILO, 2021)—independent blue-collar workers in Kenya have not fully benefited from this digital transformation. Many capable workers remain underutilized, unable to access broader markets or scale their service-based businesses beyond their immediate networks.

From the client perspective, including households and small businesses, identifying reliable and available service providers is often a time-consuming and uncertain process. The absence of a centralized and transparent system for verifying workers' skills, past performance, location, and pricing creates a trust deficit, exposing clients to delayed services, inconsistent workmanship, and the risk of overcharging or fraud. This challenge reflects a wider issue of information asymmetry within Kenya's predominantly informal labour market.

Although mobile phone usage and internet connectivity are widespread in Kenya, existing digital platforms have not adequately addressed these challenges. Kenya's mobile penetration rate exceeds 100% in subscription terms, and smartphone adoption continues to grow steadily (Communications Authority of Kenya, 2023; GSMA, 2022). However, many existing platforms prioritize established businesses or rely on competitive bidding systems that disadvantage independent workers, while offering limited support for skill verification, portfolio building, and long-term reputation development. Consequently, a large segment of the blue-collar workforce remains excluded from effective digital participation.

Given that the informal sector forms the backbone of Kenya's employment structure, the absence of a dedicated, accessible, and trust-centered digital platform represents a significant structural gap. Without such a solution, inefficiencies in service discovery, limited worker

visibility, and persistent trust deficits will continue to constrain employment opportunities and economic growth within this sector. This study therefore seeks to address this problem by investigating the design and feasibility of a mobile application-based platform that enhances visibility, trust, and access within Kenya's blue-collar labour market.

1.3 Aim of the Study

The primary aim of this study is to design and develop a mobile platform that connects independent blue-collar workers in Kenya with clients. The platform will provide instant service discovery, increase worker visibility, improve trust, and support more consistent employment opportunities. By replacing traditional word-of-mouth referrals with a transparent digital system, the study seeks to create a reliable and accessible way for clients to find skilled service providers and for workers to grow their businesses.

1.3.1 Research Objectives

To achieve the aim of this study, the following specific objectives will be pursued:

1. Analyse current challenges faced by blue-collar workers in securing employment and by clients in finding reliable service providers, including issues of visibility, trust, and access.
2. Design a user-friendly mobile platform that allows workers to create professional profiles, list their skills and services, and showcase past work.
3. Develop a booking and notification system that enables workers to quickly view and respond to job requests, improving efficiency over conventional referral methods.
4. Incorporate trust building features, such as verified profiles, ratings, and moderated reviews, to improve client confidence in the workers' skills and reliability.
5. Evaluate the platform's usability and effectiveness through user testing, focusing on its ability to improve employment opportunities for workers and provide accessible, reliable services for clients.

1.4 Significance / Justification of the Study

This study is significant because it addresses critical gaps in the employment and service delivery landscape for blue-collar workers in Kenya. By providing digital platform, the study contributes to both social and economic development in several ways:

1. **Enhanced Employment Opportunities:**
The platform provides independent blue-collar workers with digital visibility, enabling them to reach a wider client base and secure consistent work. This helps reduce underemployment and supports income stability.
2. **Improved Service Accessibility for Clients:**
Clients, including households and small businesses, can quickly find reliable, skilled,

and nearby service providers. Features like verified profiles, portfolios, and ratings reduce uncertainty, save time, and enhance trust in hiring.

3. **Trust and Transparency:**
By incorporating verification mechanisms, ratings, reviews, and portfolios, the platform builds a secure and reliable ecosystem where both workers and clients can engage confidently. This addresses a key challenge in the informal sector, where trust is often lacking.
4. **Support for Small Scale Entrepreneurship:**
The platform empowers independent workers to market their services professionally, fostering micro-entrepreneurship and enabling sustainable growth within the informal economy.

1.5 Scope

The scope of this study is limited to the design and development of a digital platform for connecting independent blue-collar workers in Kenya with clients seeking their services. The system is intended to serve individual workers, such as electricians, plumbers, painters, mechanics, and cleaners, as well as clients including households, small businesses etc.

The system will include the following features:

- **User Registration and Authentication:** Workers and clients can create accounts securely.
- **Worker Profile Management:** Workers can create professional profiles, list skills, upload portfolios of past work, specify pricing, and indicate availability.
- **Client Search and Discovery:** Clients can search for workers by service category.
- **Booking:** Develop a booking and notification system that allows workers to instantly receive, view, and respond to job requests, enhancing efficiency compared to traditional referral-based methods.
- **Ratings and Reviews:** Clients can leave feedback on completed jobs, and workers can build trust through verified profiles.
- **Basic Administration:** administrative functions for verifying worker credentials

1.6 Assumptions

The following assumptions are made in this study:

1. **Access to Devices and Internet:** Both workers and clients have access to internet-enabled devices such as smartphones or computers.
2. **Basic Digital Literacy:** Users possess a minimum level of digital literacy to navigate the platform and manage profiles or bookings.

3. Accuracy of Information: It is assumed that users will provide honest information during registration and that clients will provide fair, unbiased reviews.

1.7 Limitations

1. Limited Digital Literacy for Some Users
 - Challenge: Some workers may struggle with using mobile apps, uploading portfolios, or responding to job requests.
 - Countermeasure: Provide a simple, intuitive interface, step-by-step onboarding, tutorial videos, and optional local language support.
2. Internet Connectivity Issues
 - Challenge: Poor internet access in some areas may affect timely job requests, notifications, or platform usage.
 - Countermeasure: Optimize the platform for low-bandwidth usage, allow offline profile updates, and develop a lightweight version of the app.
3. Trust and Verification Concerns
 - Challenge: Clients may hesitate to hire unknown workers, or some workers may misrepresent skills or pricing.
 - Countermeasure: Implement verified profiles, ratings and reviews, and administrative validation to improve credibility.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter provides a comprehensive review of existing literature and digital solutions related to the connection of blue-collar workers with clients, both globally and within the Kenyan context. The purpose is to situate the proposed study within the broader discourse on digital labour platforms, informal economies, and technological interventions in service-based markets. By examining prior research and existing platforms, this review identifies gaps, challenges, and opportunities that inform the design and development of the proposed web platform. The analysis focuses on the functionality, user adoption, limitations, and socio-economic impacts of similar systems, thereby establishing a theoretical and practical foundation for this project.

2.2 Related systems

Several digital platforms in Kenya have emerged to address the challenge of connecting service providers with clients. These systems attempt to digitize access to work opportunities for informal and blue-collar workers, although with varying degrees of success.

I. Jobzy

Jobzy targets informal and blue-collar workers in sectors like cleaning, mechanics, photography, tutoring, and general service roles. In addition to job matching, Jobzy offers financial services such as savings and access to credit, aiming to enhance economic stability for workers. Its model combines employment access with financial empowerment, representing a more holistic approach to gig work. However, Jobzy's adoption remains constrained to urban centres due to reliance on smartphone-based applications and internet connectivity.

II. Jiji Kenya (Services Section)

Jiji is an online classified platform that enables individuals and businesses to advertise goods and services. Many blue-collar workers list services such as plumbing, electrical work, carpentry, and cleaning on the platform. Unlike Jobzy, Jiji operates as a non-curated marketplace, providing broad visibility but limited structured support for job matching, quality assurance, or financial services.

These systems illustrate different approaches to digital labour matching in Kenya, ranging from curated marketplaces to open classified platforms. However, none fully address the diverse needs of independent blue-collar workers across multiple trades.

2.3 Limitations/weaknesses of these systems

Despite the emergence of digital platforms aimed at connecting service providers with clients in Kenya, several limitations reduce their effectiveness in fully supporting independent blue-collar workers and service seekers.

I. Limited Worker Autonomy:

Many platforms control pricing, job allocation, or onboarding processes, which reduces workers' ability to manage their own services, negotiate directly with clients, or operate independently.

- II. **Digital Literacy Barriers:**
User interfaces are not always optimized for users with low digital literacy, limiting adoption among informal workers who may struggle with complex app navigation.
- III. **Limited Support for Long-Term Growth**
Existing platforms focus primarily on short-term task matching. Few provide tools to build a digital portfolio, showcase past work, or cultivate a long-term reputation—elements essential for sustained business growth.
- IV. **Inadequate Trust and Verification Mechanisms**
Some platforms do not robustly verify worker qualifications or client credibility, creating risks of fraud, poor-quality work, or payment disputes. Lack of trust mechanisms can discourage both clients and workers from using the platform
- V. **The "Cold Start" Problem**
New workers (Pros) found it hard to get their first job because customers only wanted to hire those with many 5-star reviews.

2.4 How the proposed solution will handle these weaknesses.

The proposed platform is designed to mitigate the identified limitations through the following ways:

- I. **User-Centred Design**
The interface will be simplified to accommodate users with varying digital literacy levels.
- II. **Enhanced Worker Autonomy**
Workers can negotiate their prices with the clients, choose tasks, and manage job schedules independently.
Direct communication channels between clients and workers for negotiation and relationship building.
- III. **Support for Long-Term Growth**
Digital portfolios for showcasing completed work.
Rating and review systems that build long-term reputations.
- IV. **Trust and Verification Mechanisms**
Verification processes for both workers and clients, including ID checks, references, or background validation.
Dispute resolution and transparent payment safeguards to reduce fraud risk.
Client and worker reviews visible to all users to reinforce accountability.
- V. **Fair Opportunity for New Workers**
To mitigate the "Cold Start" problem, the platform will allow new workers to upload verified digital portfolios showcasing previous offline work. Furthermore, newly registered accounts will receive a temporary visibility boost in search results until they establish an initial rating. This dual approach ensures equitable job access for new entrants while maintaining high quality standards through administrative moderation.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter outlines the systematic approach and procedures that will be employed to achieve the research objectives. The methodology describes the framework for designing, developing, and evaluating the proposed web platform for connecting blue-collar workers with clients in Kenya. This chapter details the system development methodology adopted, justifies its selection, describes data collection methods and tools, specifies the hardware and software resources required, presents the project schedule, and provides a preliminary budget estimate. The methodology is designed to ensure that the developed platform is technically sound, user-centred, and effectively addresses the gaps identified in the literature review.

3.2 Methodology

3.2.1 Selected Methodology: Agile

The Agile methodology is an iterative and incremental approach to software development that emphasizes flexibility, collaboration, and rapid delivery of functional software. Unlike traditional linear models such as the Waterfall method, Agile promotes continuous feedback from stakeholders and users throughout the development process. Agile development is organized into short cycles, often called sprints, which allow the project team to deliver working software in small, manageable increments. This approach enables continuous refinement of requirements, design, and functionality based on real-time feedback, ensuring the final product closely aligns with user needs.

Key principles of Agile include:

- **Iterative development:** The system is built in cycles, allowing progressive improvement and adaptation to changing requirements.
- **User-centred design:** Users and stakeholders are actively involved in the development process to ensure the platform meets their expectations.
- **Continuous feedback:** Regular testing and review sessions help identify issues early, reducing the cost and effort of late-stage modifications.
- **Collaboration:** Agile fosters effective communication between developers, clients, and end-users to ensure transparency and shared understanding.

3.2.2 Justification for Using Agile

The Agile methodology was chosen for this project due to several key advantages that align with the objectives of developing a digital platform for connecting blue-collar workers with clients:

1. **Flexibility in Requirements:** The needs of both workers and clients may evolve as the platform is developed. Agile allows the system to adapt to new requirements without major disruptions.
2. **User-Centred Development:** Regular involvement of potential users, including blue-collar workers and clients, ensures that features such as worker profiles, booking systems, and ratings meet practical needs.
3. **Early Delivery of a Minimum Viable Product (MVP):** Agile enables the creation of a functional MVP quickly, allowing initial testing and feedback before full-scale development.

4. **Risk Reduction:** Incremental development allows early detection of technical or usability issues, minimizing the risk of project failure.
5. **Enhanced Collaboration:** Agile encourages close communication between the development team, the supervisor, and prospective users, ensuring that expectations are aligned throughout the project.

In this project, Agile sprints will be used to iteratively design, develop, and refine the platform. Each sprint will focus on specific modules, such as user registration, profile management, booking, and rating systems, followed by user testing and feedback collection. This approach ensures that the final web platform is user-friendly, functional, and effectively addresses the challenges identified in connecting blue-collar workers with clients in Kenya.

3.3 Data Collection Methods and Tools / Data Sets

The success of the platform depends on understanding the needs and challenges of both blue-collar workers and clients. Primary and secondary data will be collected to guide the design, functionality, and usability of the system.

3.3.1 Data Collection Methods

1. Questionnaires:

Structured questionnaires will be administered to a sample of blue-collar workers (electricians, plumbers, painters, mechanics, and cleaners) and clients (households and small businesses). The questionnaires will include both **closed-ended questions** (e.g., multiple-choice, rating scales) and **open-ended questions** to capture qualitative insights about:

- Challenges in finding or offering services.
- Current methods used for employment or hiring.
- Expectations from a digital platform.

2. Interviews:

Semi-structured interviews will be conducted with a smaller group of workers and clients to gain deeper insights into their experiences and preferences. Interviews allow exploration of complex topics such as:

- Trust and verification concerns.
- Willingness to adopt digital solutions.
- Experiences with existing platforms like Jobzy, and Jiji.

3. Observations:

Field observations will be conducted in urban areas where informal blue-collar work is common. This method helps understand:

- How workers interact with clients in real-life scenarios.
- Challenges in scheduling, location, and reliability.
- Typical work patterns and client behaviors.

4. Secondary Data Collection:

Relevant literature, reports, and case studies from similar platforms will be analysed to understand:

- Features of existing platforms.
- Successes and failures of digital labour marketplaces.
- Trends in mobile usage and internet adoption in Kenya.

3.3.2 Data Collection Tools

- **Google Forms:** For distributing and collecting questionnaire responses digitally.
- **Audio Recording Devices / Note-taking Templates:** For capturing interview data accurately.
- **Observation Checklists:** To standardize the collection of field data on worker-client interactions.
- **Statistical Software / Spreadsheet Tools (e.g., Excel):** For organizing and analyzing quantitative data collected from surveys.

3.3.3 Data Sets

Primary Data Sets:

- **Worker Dataset:** Includes information such as age, trade, years of experience, preferred payment methods, and prior experience with digital platforms.
- **Client Dataset:** Includes demographic information, frequency of service requests, preferred methods of finding workers, and satisfaction with current service delivery.

Secondary Data Sets:

- Published statistics on smartphone adoption, internet usage, and digital platform penetration in Kenya.
- Case studies and reports on similar platforms (e.g. Jobzy, Jiji) for benchmarking and gap analysis.

Data Quality Considerations:

- Ensuring that survey and interview questions are clear, concise, and unbiased.
- Sampling workers and clients from multiple urban and peri-urban areas to capture diversity.
- Verifying responses for consistency and accuracy.

3.4 Project Resources

The development of the proposed platform requires both hardware and software resources to ensure smooth design, development, and testing.

Hardware Requirements:

- **Developer Devices:** Laptops or desktops with minimum specifications of 8GB RAM, Intel i5 processor, and 256GB SSD for development and testing.

- **Mobile Devices:** Android and iOS smartphones for testing responsiveness, usability, and mobile functionality.
- **Internet Access:** Stable internet connection for development, cloud hosting, and accessing APIs.

Software Requirements:

- **Frontend Development:** HTML, CSS, JavaScript, and frameworks like React.js or Angular.
- **Backend Development:** Node.js, Python (Django/Flask), or PHP (Laravel) for server-side programming.
- **Database Management:** MySQL, PostgreSQL, or MongoDB for storing user and service data.
- **Version Control:** Git/GitHub for source code management and collaboration.
- **Design and Prototyping:** Figma, Adobe XD, or Sketch for UI/UX design and high-fidelity prototypes.
- **Testing Tools:** Postman for API testing, browser developer tools.

3.5 Project Schedule

The project will be executed over a **12-week period** using the Agile methodology. The schedule is organized into overlapping sprints to allow iterative development and continuous feedback from users:

Table 3.1: Project Schedule

Phase	Activities	Duration
Requirement Analysis	User surveys, interviews, literature review	2 weeks
System Design	UI/UX design, database schema, platform architecture	2 weeks
Development (MVP)	Frontend & backend development, database integration	4 weeks
Testing & Feedback	Unit testing, user acceptance testing, bug fixes	2 weeks
Refinement & Deployment	Implement improvements, final deployment	1 week
Documentation & Reporting	Thesis write-up, user manuals, final report	1 week

Total Duration: 12 weeks, with Agile sprints enabling iterative improvements and timely delivery of a functional platform.

3.6 Project Budget

The estimated budget for the project includes software, hardware, internet costs, and miscellaneous expenses:

Table 3.2: Project Budget

Item	Description	Estimated Cost (KES)
Hardware	Laptop, smartphones for testing	80,000
Software Licenses / Tools	Figma, Adobe XD, cloud hosting, database tools	25,000
Internet & Data	Mobile data, broadband for 4 months	8,000
User Testing Incentives	Tokens or small compensations for survey/interview participants	8,000
Miscellaneous Expenses	Printing, documentation, transport	5,000
Total Estimated Budget		126,000 KES

This budget ensures adequate resources for successful development, testing, and deployment of the platform while maintaining quality and reliability.

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